0–2 → 3–2

DATA ANALYSIS · FIFA WORLD CUP 2026

Minute 66. Argentina 0–2. Three Goals. One Comeback.

The comeback was real — and data can measure how rare it was. But a sharper question spread across the timeline afterward: has Argentina really been FIFA's "golden child" since 2022? We test that claim with data, not opinion, and measure how much confidence the data deserves.

Reproducible data research · dataset, code, and notebook available publicly at https://github.com/Shiverion/argentina-comeback-analysis

The scoreboard at Atlanta Stadium read **Argentina 0 – Egypt 2**. The match clock showed the 66th minute, and Mostafa Zico had just doubled Egypt's lead. To anyone watching, the game looked finished. Argentina, the defending champion, was heading out of the 2026 World Cup in the Round of 16 — against Egypt.

What happened next became an overnight legend: Cristian Romero in the 78th minute, Lionel Messi in the 82nd, and Enzo Fernández in the 91st turned the match into a **3–2** win. But one detail is easy to lose inside the "miracle comeback" story: in the 20th minute, long before the late drama, Messi missed a penalty that could have prevented Argentina from falling behind in the first place. The attempt was blocked by Egypt's goalkeeper and recorded in FIFA's official match report. Argentina did not just survive a late miracle; it had also wasted a major early chance.

> *"How unlikely was this comeback, really? And has Argentina actually received more favorable officiating since 2022?"*

Those two questions spread online as soon as the final whistle blew. One is a straightforward sports-statistics question. The other is much more sensitive: the claim that FIFA has systematically favored Argentina since the 2022 Qatar final. This article answers both in the same way: with data that anyone can inspect and reproduce. The full dataset, analysis code, and notebook behind every number are **openly available** at `https://github.com/Shiverion/argentina-comeback-analysis` — including the places where the data is not strong enough to give a definitive answer.

Part 1 · How Rare Was This Comeback, Really?

To answer fairly, we did not compare the match with subjective memories of other dramatic games. We examined **964 men's World Cup matches** from 1930 through 2022 using the Fjelstul World Cup Database and asked: among all teams that had ever been two or more goals down late in a match, what share eventually won in regulation time?

0 of 278	0 of 316	< 1.4%
TWO-GOAL COMEBACKS AT 70′	TWO-GOAL COMEBACKS AT 80′	95% UPPER BOUND ON THE RATE

The result is consistent and stark: across 964 men's World Cup matches, not one team had turned a two-goal deficit at minutes 70, 75, 78, or 80 into a regulation-time win before Argentina

did it in 2026. Even the upper bound of the statistical uncertainty interval stayed below 1.4%.

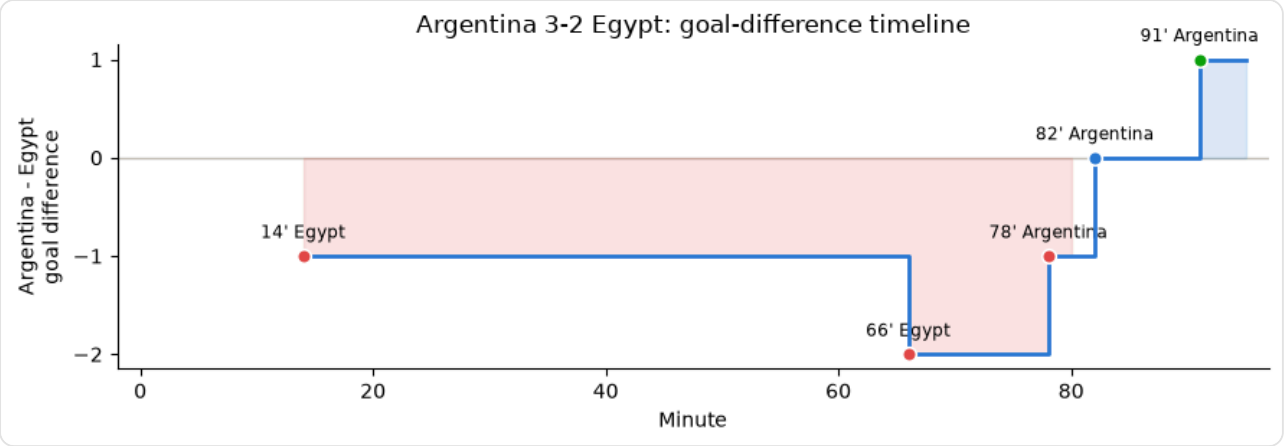


Figure 1. Argentina's goal difference throughout the match. Red indicates an Argentina deficit; blue indicates a lead. The equalizer (82′) and winner (91′) both arrived in the final nine minutes of regulation time.

ROBUSTNESS CHECK To make sure the result was not driven by including the very different football of the 1930s, we repeated the calculation using only matches since 1970, 1998, and 2010. Every era slice still produced **zero comebacks** at every threshold minute. Only the uncertainty changed: smaller samples produce wider upper bounds, reaching 5.7% in the 2010-and-later slice. The direction of the finding did not move.

LARGER SAMPLE We also repeated the test on a broader dataset: 2,193 matches from a selected club-football sample outside the World Cup. Here the result was **not literally zero**: there were 2 cases among 703 relevant matches at minute 70, roughly 1 in 300–700. They were **Leicester City** at home to Aston Villa and **West Ham United** away to Everton, both in the 2015/16 English Premier League. This sharpens rather than cancels the original finding: the event is extremely rare, but not mathematically impossible.

A Wider Window: Rare, Not Impossible

A World Cup record can look absolute because the sample is small. The larger club sample adds context, using the same counting rule while remaining a separate population.

2 / 703
CLUB COMEBACKS AT 70′

1 / 733
CLUB COMEBACKS AT 75′

0 / 764
CLUB COMEBACKS AT 80′

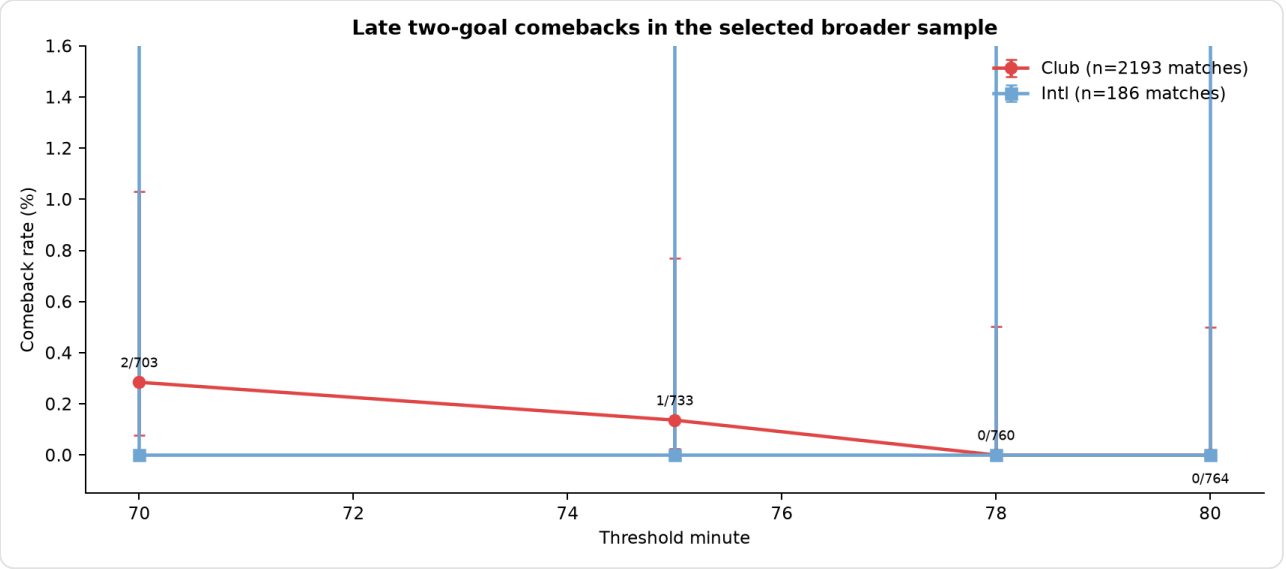


Figure 2. Selected StatsBomb sample: the numerator and denominator are shown together so the rarity is not detached from the sample size.

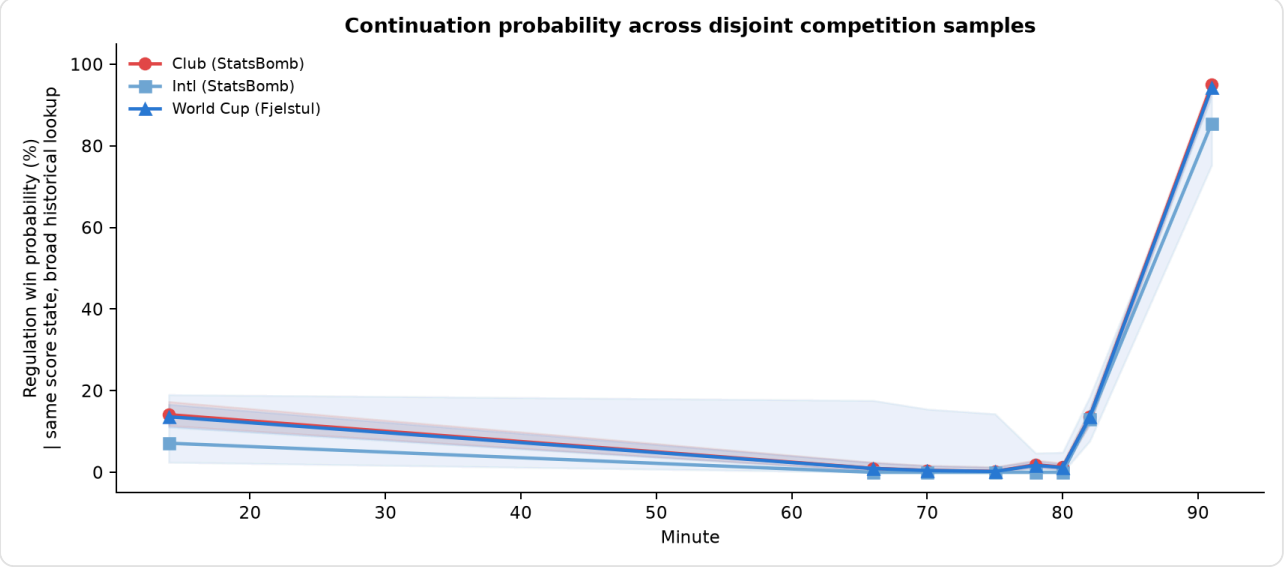


Figure 3. Continuation curves for World Cup, club, and non-World-Cup international matches. This is a cross-check on separate match records, not evidence that the club sample represents all club football.

> **Sample note:** StatsBomb contains additional senior competitions, but this project uses an explicit competition-season allowlist. Those competitions were not silently treated as nonexistent; the coverage limitation is recorded in `config/sources.json`.

So What Was Argentina's Exact Win Probability?

This is where data honesty matters. There are two defensible ways to estimate Argentina's chance of winning from 0–2 down, and they differ by **an order of magnitude**. The first compares Argentina with *every* historical team that was in the same deficit, including weak teams that were rarely likely to recover. The second compares only situations where the trailing team had strength comparable to Argentina, using Elo ratings. That is more relevant, but leaves a very small comparison set, sometimes only 1–3 matches.

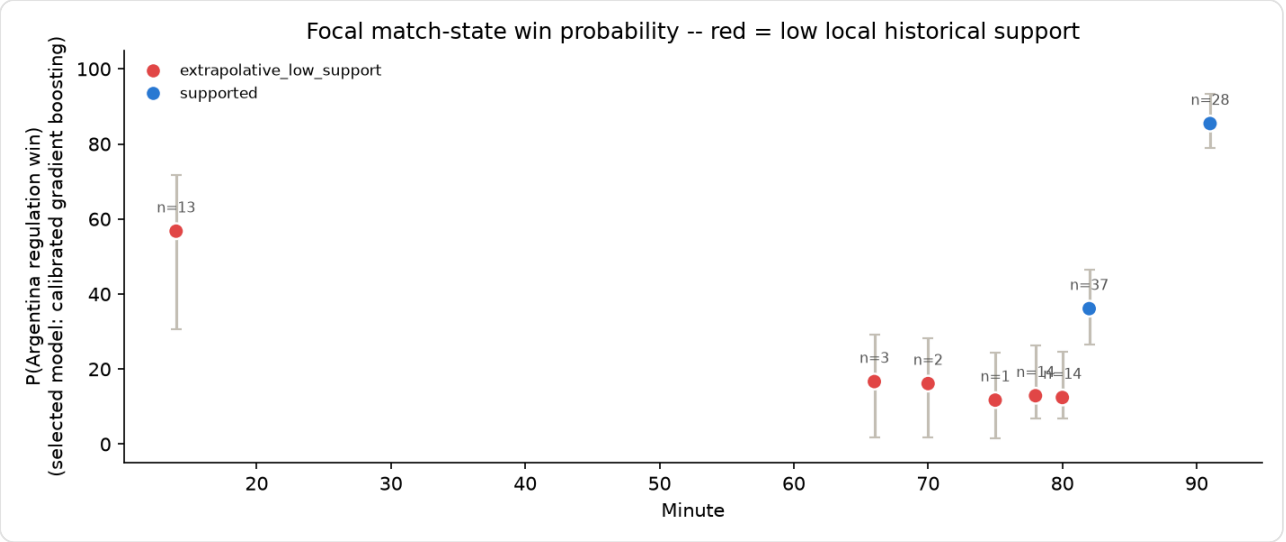


Figure 4. Argentina's modelled win probability at key match moments, using strength-matched historical situations. Red points have too little comparison data for full confidence (n = 1–14); blue points have more support (n = 28–37).

The honest conclusion is a range, not a precise point estimate: Argentina's chance at minutes 66–80 while 0–2 down was almost certainly low, probably somewhere from the low single digits to the high teens, but the available data cannot narrow that range responsibly. Anyone quoting "only X%" without showing how many historical matches produced the estimate is flattening a genuinely uncertain problem.

Part 2 · What If Egypt's Disallowed Goal Had Stood?

One of the match's most debated moments was an Egypt goal disallowed by VAR while the score was still 0–1. Public reports disagree about its exact minute (58, 62, or 67), and the incident has **not been verified through official video**. We therefore cannot and will not claim that the decision was wrong. What we can calculate is the counterfactual: *if* the goal had stood, how much would Argentina's modelled win probability have changed?

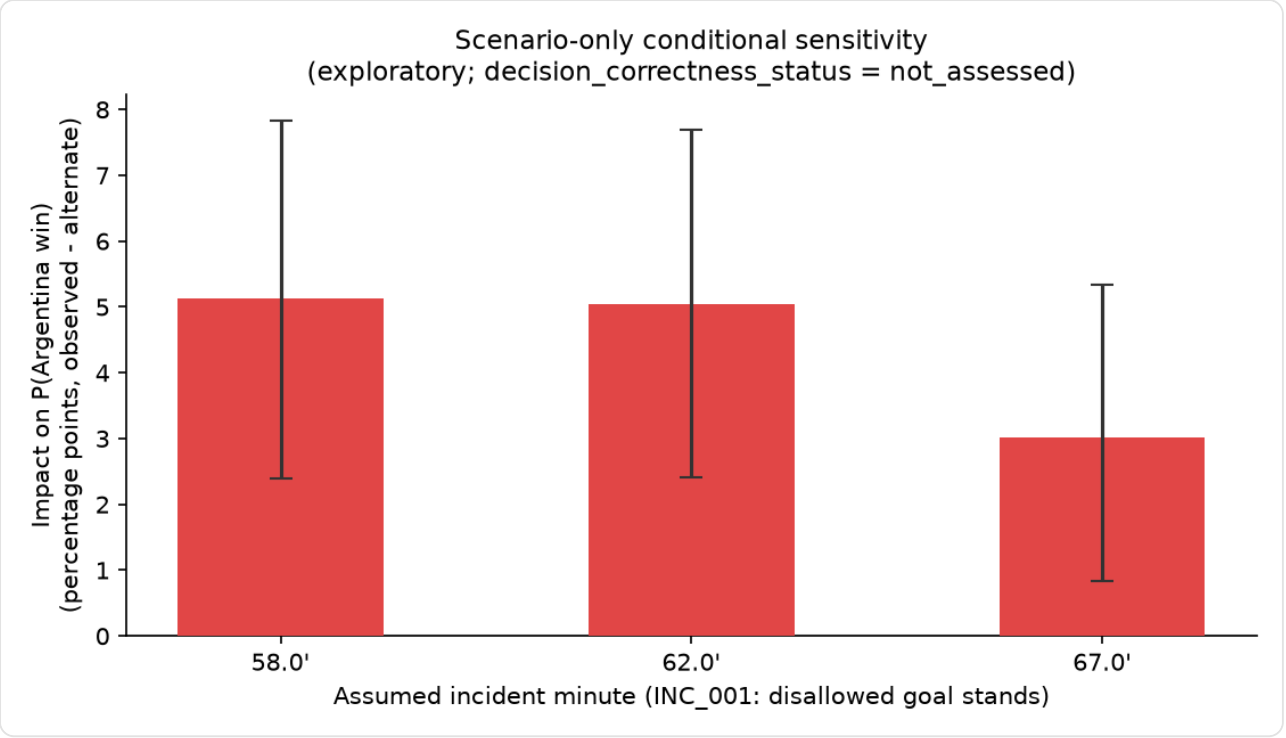


Figure 5. Change in Argentina's win probability if the disallowed goal had counted, evaluated at three possible reported minutes. Vertical lines show the statistical bootstrap interval.

IMPORTANT LIMIT Under all three timing assumptions, allowing the goal would have reduced Argentina's modelled win probability by **3–5 percentage points**, and the uncertainty interval did not cross zero. That makes the counterfactual statistically material. It is **not** evidence that the officiating decision was wrong, much less evidence of corruption; that would require video review and the relevant official rules, which are outside the scope of public match-event data.

Part 3 · Is Argentina Really FIFA's "Golden Child" Since 2022?

This question is much larger than one match. The claim is that, since the 2022 World Cup final, Argentina has systematically received favorable officiating decisions. To test it fairly across years and teams, we measured Argentina's penalties, yellow cards, and red cards against *every team in the field* at each World Cup edition since 1930, then ranked Argentina's per-match rate as a percentile within that edition's field.

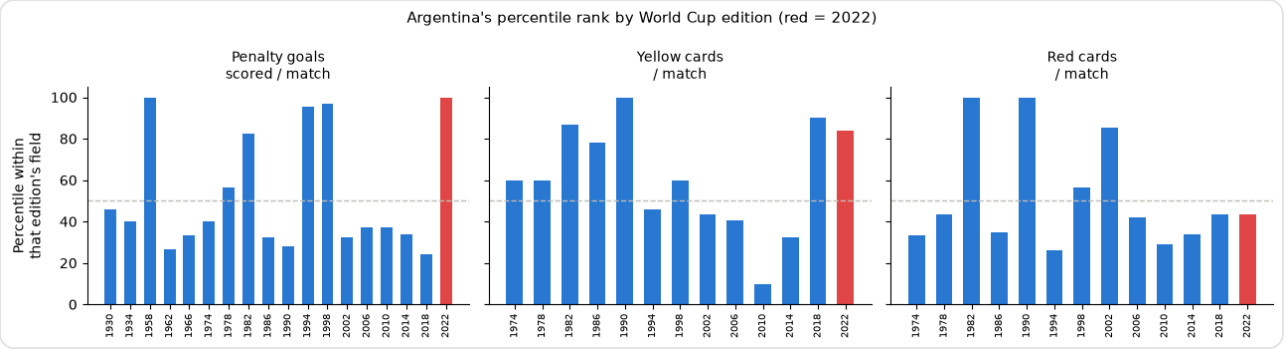


Figure 6. Argentina's percentile against every team in the same edition for three different metrics. Red marks 2022. Cards are computed only from 1970 onward, because the card system did not exist earlier.

AN HONEST CORRECTION An earlier draft incorrectly calculated Argentina's 2022 red-card percentile as **88%**, making it appear unusually high. The old formula mishandled ties, especially the many teams with zero red cards. Argentina actually had zero red cards in 2022, and **28 of the 32 teams** in that field also had zero. The correct tie-aware percentile is **43.5%**, almost exactly the middle of the field. We corrected this publicly because the mistake exaggerated the bias narrative rather than weakening it.

The data does show that Argentina's 2022 penalty-goal rate was high, at the 100th percentile, and its yellow-card rate was above average, at the 84th percentile. But this is **not a pattern that began in 2022**. Argentina also reached the 100th percentile for penalty goals in 1958, while 1982 and 1990 matched or exceeded 2022 on red cards. If preferential treatment truly began in 2022, we would expect a sharp new step at that tournament. The data does not show one. The observed pattern looks at least as compatible with a consistently attacking, high-possession team spending more time in opponents' penalty areas across different generations and refereeing eras.

What About 2026?

For a current check, we extracted the official FIFA reports for **all 96 matches** played through the 2026 Round of 16, a full census rather than a sample, and counted penalties *awarded* to each team. This includes saved and missed penalties, not only converted kicks — including Messi's missed 20th-minute penalty.

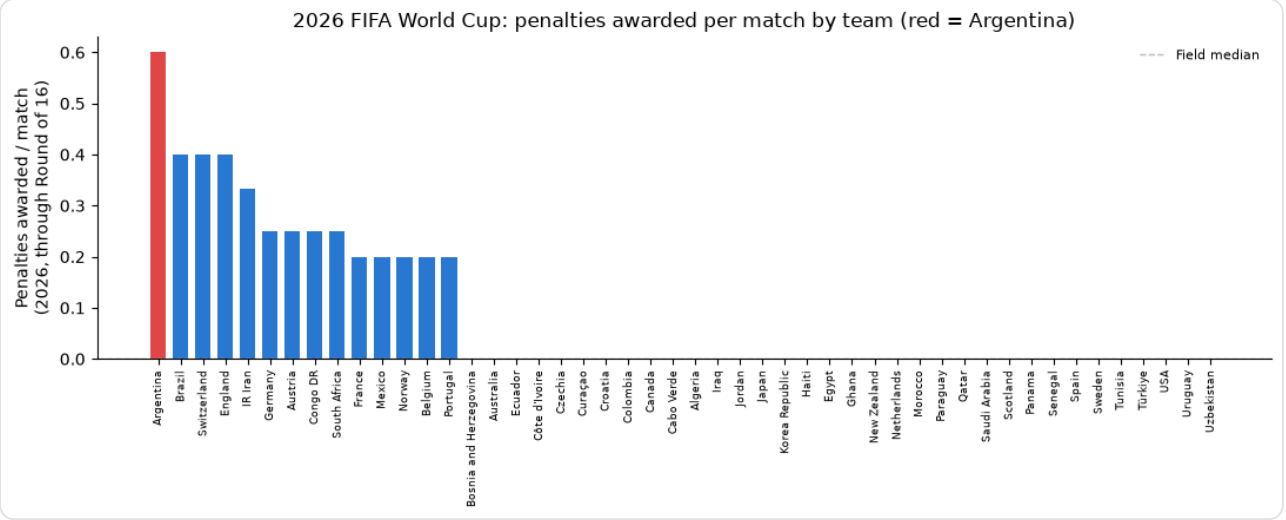


Figure 7. Penalties awarded per match for every team at the 2026 World Cup through the Round of 16, covering all 48 teams. Argentina leads the field.

METHODOLOGICAL NOTE The 2026 metric, "penalties awarded," and the 1930–2022 metric, "penalty goals scored," measure different things from different source documents. They **must not be combined** into a single statistic.

Argentina currently leads the 48-team field with 3 penalties in 5 matches, or 0.60 per match, slightly ahead of Brazil, Switzerland, and England at 0.40. But this tournament is still in progress: teams have played only 3–5 matches, and the field median is zero. Read alongside the 1930–2022 chart, this is a second data point pointing in the same direction as the 2022 result, not independent proof. It is also just as compatible with a simpler explanation: an elite, ball-dominant, relentlessly attacking team spends more time in the opponent's box and therefore mechanically creates more penalty opportunities.

Conclusion: What the Evidence Does and Does Not Support

Claim	Supported?
This comeback was statistically rare	**Yes, strongly.** Zero comparable events in 964 historical matches at every threshold and across every era slice.
One officiating decision had material sensitivity	**Yes, conditionally.** The disallowed-goal scenario shows a 3–5 percentage-point effect, but the incident is not validated.
Repeated officiating decisions favored one side	**Not established.** No incident in this match currently has video-reviewed or officially confirmed status.
FIFA intentionally favored or manipulated outcomes for Argentina	**Not assessable** from public match statistics alone.

Public match statistics, however rich, have limits. They can tell us how rare an outcome was, how much an alternate scenario changes a modelled probability, and whether a numerical pattern is consistent across time. They **cannot** read a referee's intent, prove corruption, or settle the correctness of a decision without video and the official rules. Argentina's comeback is statistically one of the rarest in World Cup history. But "rare" and "rigged" are entirely different claims, and this dataset can answer only one of them.

Methods & transparency. Every number in this article is generated by a reproducible data pipeline, not typed by hand. The ETL code, fully executed Jupyter notebook, compact outputs, provenance, and instructions for downloading the pinned raw StatsBomb event cache are publicly available at:
https://github.com/Shiverion/argentina-comeback-analysis

Notebook: `output/jupyter-notebook/argentina_egypt_comeback_analysis.ipynb` · Full technical report: `results/analysis_report.md` · Data provenance: `config/sources.json`